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By Invitation | News flash: kids aren't all the same

How the young use AI matters more than for how long

That undermines the case for blanket bans or time limits, writes Sema Sgaier

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C ONVENTIONAL WISDOM is forming quickly. Social-media use damages young people's mental health and generative artificial intelligence is now eroding their ability to think. The anxiety is understandable. AI tools have spread through teenage social lives with extraordinary speed, prompting calls for age limits, bans on "AI companions" and tighter guardrails. But the debate assumes that AI affects all young people in broadly the same way and often treats time spent using it as the main measure of risk. Emerging evidence suggests the opposite. The same technology can expand opportunity for some youngsters while quietly replacing human support for others.

How might a young person's social and emotional context play a role in how, when and why they use generative-AI tools? And what does this mean for how policies should be shaped? A team at the health-data firm I run addressed these questions in a large study of 13- to 24-year-olds in America, conducted in November 2025. We asked over 100 questions about AI use, its impacts on their lives, and their broader mental health and life context.

We find high-frequency AI users who are thriving and low-frequency users who are in deep distress. The same tool functions radically differently depending on a user's socioeconomic context, the types of events that trigger stress for them and their "human capital": the skills and knowledge they possess. Young people use AI in strikingly different ways.

For some, AI functions as a mobility engine. One in ten young people are optimistic

“power users” and treat generative AI as a tool for learning and opportunity, using it to build skills, generate ideas and explore new career paths. Over two-thirds of this group say AI opens new opportunities, while more than half say it gives them confidence to solve problems and feel more hopeful about the world. Black youth and those facing economic hardship are particularly likely to fall into this group, suggesting that AI can expand access to knowledge and opportunity where other resources are scarce.

For a similar-sized group, AI becomes a substitute for social and emotional support that is missing offline. This worrying group turns to AI for conversation, emotional reassurance and advice when they feel isolated. These high-frequency users report higher levels of distress and are disproportionately likely to face bullying, discrimination or financial strain. AI may indeed be better than no support at all. But general-purpose systems are not designed to play this role safely. They cannot reliably recognise when to direct a young person to professional help.

And then there are those who keep their distance from the technology altogether. This group, which accounts for roughly a tenth of young people, does not see AI as a practical tool. They are anxious about its impact. Their low engagement is more a reflection of their broader societal pessimism than of negative experiences they have had with the technology. We find white and LGBTQ+ youth to be overrepresented in this group. For LGBTQ+ youth, AI exacerbates their anxiety with surveillance and privacy concerns.

Close to half of young people, however, fall somewhere in between. They engage with AI pragmatically, using it to explore, learn and solve problems, without relying on it for identity or emotional support. Strong social support and a sense of belonging appear

to act as buffers, allowing these young people to treat AI as a tool rather than a substitute for connection.

What does this mean for policy and practice? The instinct to regulate access or impose time limits may be misguided. Recent proposals, from school bans on ChatGPT to America's federal GUARD Act, reflect an impulse to reduce exposure as the primary safety mechanism. If AI is functioning as a mobility engine for some young people, a productivity tool for others and an emotional substitute for those lacking support, then exposure alone is the wrong variable to regulate. What's needed is a multi-pronged approach that complements the complex ways in which this technology weaves through young people's lives and, in many ways, mirrors it.

Designing AI systems with strong and smart safety guardrails is essential. Firms have a responsibility to ensure their systems do not expose young users to harmful interactions, and policymakers should hold them accountable. Some governments, such as California's and New York's, are already moving in this direction, with proposals to require clearer disclosures and limit emotionally manipulative design. But product-level fixes alone are insufficient.

The important question is what role the technology ends up playing. Policy should focus on where AI begins to substitute for human support and whether that substitution is safe. That means building paths from AI tools to human care, such as easy connections to mental-health services, and equipping schools and families with the literacy to help youngsters navigate these systems.

Trusted adults are central to this. There is often a disconnect between what parents think their children are using AI for and how they are actually using it. Yet parents and trusted adults remain the most important facilitators of support. Helping them engage

in more informed conversations about AI rather than just restricting it will be critical. Expert guidance suggests these conversations should focus on helping teens understand what AI can and cannot do, discussing privacy risks and encouraging critical thinking about AI responses. There are important lessons here from how we failed to equip parents in relation to social-media use.

In short, the debate needs to shift. Instead of asking only how much time the young spend with AI, the question should be about how the technology fits into the social environments shaping their lives. Generative AI will not determine youngsters' well-being on its own. But it may reveal and sometimes amplify the strengths, or the absences, in the human support systems around them. ■

Sema Sgaier is the co-founder and chief executive of Surgo Health.

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